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RE: Reference letter for Luckie Musngi

To whom it may concern,

It is my pleasure to provide this *strong letter of recommendation* for Luckie Musngi. This recommendation letter is somewhat unusual in that I am providing it *unsolicited* – Luckie did not ask for it – but I felt compelled to offer it due to Luckie's exemplary performance in my rapid prototyping class.

How I know Luckie: Luckie took my introductory rapid prototyping course (ISTA 303), which covers 3D printing, laser cutting, and electronics, during Fall 2025. This course involves extensive one-on-one interaction and daily mentorship with the instructor, allowing me to become very familiar with students' abilities, work habits, and technical strengths.

Recommendation: ISTA 303 uses project-based learning to teach rapid prototyping. Rather than relying on traditional exams, students learn by doing and demonstrate their skills through largely self-directed projects. The course culminates in a month-long final project (serving as a proxy for a final exam) in which students must design, construct, and iteratively refine a machine of their own design that sorts a bag of Skittles by color as quickly and accurately as possible. While this task initially appears straightforward to most students, they quickly discover that building reliable physical systems—requiring sensing, electronics, motors and actuators, and mechanical design that must function consistently in the real world—is quite challenging.

We have run this final project as a design competition for over a decade. **Luckie Musngi not only won the 2025 competition, but produced a remarkable and unconventional design that outperformed every Skittle sorter created in the past ten years by hundreds of computer scientists and engineers.** It is a truly impressive piece of engineering.

Having guided hundreds of students through this process, the skills that distinguish Luckie from past students are as follows:

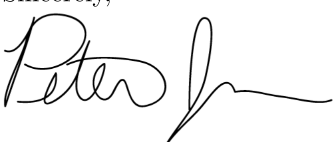
1. Luckie demonstrated an exceptional ability to listen carefully and incorporate feedback. To give one example, he occasionally encountered mechanical challenges (such as jamming in his feeding mechanism), but was able to rapidly absorb guidance on material beyond the formal scope of the course (e.g., bearings) and apply it almost immediately. I have taught these concepts to many students before; whereas many partially absorb the lesson and require days or weeks to implement it effectively, Luckie understood the issue within minutes and immediately applied the feedback to improve his machine. This pattern repeated itself multiple times throughout the project.
2. Luckie excelled at rapid iteration. A core principle of rapid prototyping is quickly iterating designs to identify failures inexpensively and develop effective solutions, thereby dramatically reducing the time required to complete a project. More than most students I have taught in this course, Luckie fully embraced this philosophy. He iterated constantly, and I understand that he often worked into the early hours of the morning in the engineering design center to refine and improve his project.
3. Luckie was a highly independent thinker. While he sought guidance when appropriate, he generally solved challenging problems with minimal supervision. He was able to take either high-level or low-level feedback, translate it into a concrete action plan, and execute whatever steps were necessary to achieve his goals.
4. Luckie was very easy going. He is personable, and low stress – he didn't worry about getting things done, he just made it happen.
5. On a more personal level, Luckie's project wasn't just good – it was obnoxiously good. Where most students tend to build machines that are quite delicate, require frequent repair, and barely work for the duration of the design competition, Luckie would walk into class with his machine slung over his back, casually toss it on his workbench, fire it up, and it would *just work*. While others were trying to figure out why their machines kept breaking, his was designed to be very robust from the start, so he could spend his time focusing on the task rather than repairing technical debt.

Overall Recommendation: Selecting new staff members is always challenging. It's no secret that grades are often a poor predictor of future success, and that many students lack sufficient experience completing large, open-ended projects to build a meaningful portfolio, making it hard to know if they're likely to be successful. Luckie stands out as a rare student who is self-motivated, intellectually agile, and capable of executing complex projects efficiently with strong time-management skills – all of which are a very uncommon combination. He ranks in the 99^{th} percentile of undergraduates I have taught in this course over the past decade, and he has my strong recommendation based on both his record-breaking performance and my mentorship interactions with him over the term.

My background: I am Dr. Peter Jansen, PhD, an Associate Professor (with tenure) in the College of Information at the University of Arizona, an R1 (very-high research activity) institution in the United States. I am also a Visiting Research Scientist at the Allen Institute for Artificial Intelligence (Ai2), which is frequently recognized as one of the top research institutes for AI in the United States. I am an interdisciplinary natural language processing (NLP) researcher, generally specializing in how we can teach language models to perform inference, particularly in the context of scientific reasoning, and agent-centered reasoning in virtual environments. I am author or co-author of approximately 50 scientific articles, many in top-tier venues in my field, such as ACL, EMNLP, AAAI, NeurIPS, and ICLR. My research has been externally funded by the Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency (DARPA), National Science Foundation (NSF), National Institute of Health (NIH), and the Allen Institute for Artificial Intelligence (Ai2). I am an award winning educator, and both my research and non-traditional approach to grounding science education has been featured in over 50 news articles in popular international news media, including Reuters, Forbes, and New Scientist.

If you have any questions or require further information, please feel free to contact me.

Sincerely,



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